



A whole new world of (tech) innovations!

From the point of view of technologists, the OS may usher in possibilities to create new tools and technologies, believe experts. Touch-ability, surface computing, easy connect with the cloud, and removal of a few devices that were hitherto considered integral part of computers, are some of the Windows 7 features that hold a promise for interesting innovations in the future. We did a little future gazing to enumerate a few possibilities:

Computing for a new segment of users. Most of the world population still doesn't have access to computing. Although many people like children, old people, people who are at low affluence or literacy levels, may want to use PC, there are many deterrents that inhibit them from working on computing devices, says Kiran Mani, director—business strategy and marketing, OEM business, Microsoft India.

One of the key inhibitors is language. Unlike the telecom technology, where sharing or accessing information requires merely punching in a few numbers, for users to work on a PC requires a certain level of literacy. But if users can have access to PCs through touch interface, they may not need input commands via keyboards.

Windows 7 offers a solution to address such problems, affirms Mani. "When Windows 7 was conceived, one of Microsoft's considerations was to remove the language barrier and the need to have conventional input devices, like mouse and keyboard. This is when the multi-touch became such a significant feature for the OS and the new-age machine," he adds.

(Touch)-enabling innovations. Multi-touch can prove to be a feature that has huge industrial relevance and may lead to interesting innovations. Mani agrees and feels that gesture and touch commands in Windows 7 may revolutionise the human-machine interaction methods as 'touch' functionality takes off the need to punch in commands. Taking the thought further, Mani cites an example of how this could have significant relevance for old people. "A touch-enabled device can empower an old couple, living alone, to have a conversation with their doctor while sitting in their front room; have their medical order being placed; search for convenient food options over the Internet, and so on."

Complete convergence. Till now, almost all entertainment and computing functions have remained independent activities for users, like watching movies on TV, listening to music on iPod or music system, or computing on PCs. But Windows 7 offers a seamless integration of many of

these functions or devices through its 'Home Network' feature. It allows users to connect many electronic devices in the household and transfer data from PC to devices like TV or music system, and allows them to view/play it on these devices.

The integration of many electronics, computing and entertainment devices may throw open many possibilities. A company in India is already working on integrating a 106.7 cm touchscreen TV with a PC to come up with a new computing-cum-entertainment device, shares Mani.

Smartphones may Net-connect, smartly. Today, we have a lot of smartphones in use but there are technology gaps that still nag; the key one being the speed of the Internet access. But Mani says that with the advent of 3G and wireless computing, and with an OS that connects a lot more faster with the cloud, smartphones may become a lot more useful.

Surface computing. With Windows 7, surface computing may also become an important future point for innovations. "Use of surface computing for healthcare is extremely well documented. A good example is that of a table-top device on which you can keep a medicine bottle and it throws up light at a pre-decided time to alert the user/patient to take the medicine. The light switches off when the patient picks up the medicine," explains Mani. Even a table-top may suddenly turn into a computing or electronic device, which in turn can enable development of a lot many new devices, he avers.

Ushering in the era of 64-bit computing. A lot of notebooks and PCs are being shipped with 64-bit version of Windows 7. Hence, Windows 7 is expected to make 64-bit computing main stream, thinks Milind Mody, CEO, eBrandz. "Windows 7 achieved more than 4 per cent of market share (within a few weeks of release). Which means sales of Windows 7 compatible software will also gain momentum," he shares. This means an opportunity for software vendors to bring out new versions of their software that utilise 64-bit computing.

Game-developers' delight. For game developers the OS, which is a lot more feature driven, may prove to be a useful platform to create rich innovative products, avers Mani. Also, gamers and power users (like programmers or graphics designers) will benefit from the 64-bit processing, feels Mody.

The vernacular edge. The OS comes with a multi-lingual user interface that supports 11 Indian languages, which makes it relevant for people who are not conversant with English. This also opens up an opportunity to build vernacular applications around the OS, says Mani.

In other words, things that were earlier considered as fascinations may suddenly turn real, affirms Mani.